Dental Insurance Verification Checklist

The verification pass that stops denials before the appointment

Most avoidable denials trace back to a verification that was done once, at registration, and never repeated. This checklist is what a complete verification looks like.

1. Confirm the patient is who the card says

- [ ] Member ID, group number, date of birth and effective date captured from the card, not from memory.
- [ ] Eligibility confirmed electronically on the day of the appointment, not at the last visit.
- [ ] Primary and secondary plans both verified, with coordination of benefits order confirmed.
- [ ] If the patient is a dependent, the subscriber's details are on file and current.

2. Capture the benefit facts that change your estimate

- [ ] Deductible remaining, both individual and family.
- [ ] Annual maximum remaining and whether it has already been used this year.
- [ ] Coverage percentage for diagnostic, basic and major categories.
- [ ] Frequency limits on cleanings, radiographs, crowns, periodontal therapy and replacements.
- [ ] Waiting periods that are still running, with the date each one ends.
- [ ] Missing tooth clause, and whether it applies to this patient's record.

3. Check the plan rules that cause silent denials

- [ ] Does the plan require pre-authorization for major restorative or surgical work?
- [ ] Is there a participating or non-participating fee schedule difference?
- [ ] Are there alternate benefit provisions for the codes you expect to place?
- [ ] Does the plan restrict who can perform certain services, such as a specialist referral requirement?
- [ ] Is this provider still in network for this specific member's plan?

4. Document what you found

- [ ] Save the eligibility response, screenshot or reference number, in the patient's record.

- [ ] Write down the rep's name, the call date and the reference number for anything verbal.
- [ ] Record the date the verification was done so the next check knows how stale it is.
- [ ] Flag anything ambiguous for a second call before treatment, not after billing.

5. Hand it to the patient before they sit down

- [ ] Estimate shows what the plan is expected to pay and what the patient owes.
- [ ] The estimate names the specific limits used, so the patient understands the number.
- [ ] Payment terms confirmed and signed before treatment starts.
- [ ] Reverify before any appointment where the treatment plan changes category.

Bottom line: Verification is not a registration task. It is the first billing step, and it should be repeated whenever the plan, the year or the treatment plan changes.